



Rob Thomas

Senior VP, Software & Chief Commercial Officer

Not disclosed

Revenue

Armonk

HQ

01 Who You're Meeting

Rob Thomas — Senior VP, Software & Chief Commercial Officer, IBM watsonx.

In role: SVP of Software and Chief Commercial Officer since 2023

Today: Runs IBM's software business — product management, design, development and business development — and carries global responsibility for IBM revenue and profit, including worldwide sales, strategic partnerships and the ecosystem.

The single most important commercial counterpart at IBM after Krishna, and a twenty-plus-year insider who built the business watsonx now sits on. He has held roles across IBM Consulting, IBM Microelectronics and IBM Software, including two years based in Tokyo. He joined the software business in 2007 focused on data and analytics, and led IBM's transition from databases to broader analytical capabilities, its investment in open source, and eventually its move into artificial intelligence.

Career: Senior Vice President, Software & Chief Commercial Officer, IBM; Senior Vice President, IBM Global Markets, IBM; Senior Vice President, Cloud and Data Platform, IBM Software; Data and analytics — product engineering and business development, IBM Software

Education: Vanderbilt University

The company: A governance-first enterprise AI platform riding IBM's existing enterprise relationships rather than a vertical infrastructure play — the most horizontal (industry-agnostic) offering on this list.

What they sell: watsonx.ai (foundation-model studio), watsonx.data (data lakehouse) and watsonx.governance (AI lifecycle/risk/compliance), built around IBM's Granite models plus open-source and third-party models.

02 Where The Company Sits

Overlaps with Sand mainly on AI governance and enterprise deployment discipline, not on physical-infrastructure control; IBM's brand and balance sheet dwarf every other name here except Siemens.

03 Talking Points

- Product and commerce in one person — he can commit on both capability and price without escalating.
- He built the data and analytics business that watsonx descends from, so the data-foundation argument is his own history rather than a pitch.
- He writes publicly about agents acting rather than advising, and about data lagging behind agent decisions. That is a good opening if data readiness is your concern.

What to pressure-test about the company:

- Some internal reviewers note limited hands-on usage — one employee described watsonx training as done "for the sake of training" with little real deployment exposure
- Complex initial user experience flagged by Gartner Peer Insights reviewers, especially for less technical teams
- No physical-infrastructure specialization — competes as a horizontal platform against nimbler vertical specialists

04 GIP Context

GIP: No connection found. IBM's enterprise client base is broad enough that overlap with a GIP portfolio company is plausible, but no specific relationship was confirmed in available sources.

BlackRock: Confirmed passive ownership — BlackRock holds a ~\$18.8B stake in IBM (77.6M shares as of Q1 2026), its largest institutional holder ahead of Vanguard and State Street.

Others at IBM watsonx: Arvind Krishna (Chairman & CEO, IBM)

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Public professional and company information from the research layer of the GIP vendor tracker, generated September 15, 2026. Figures are as reported by the sources listed on the vendor's white page and are not independently audited. Research goes stale — re-run before external use.